

THE 5 LOVE LANGUAGES

The Secret to Love that Lasts

Gary Chapman

The Big "So What"



Many marriages fail not because couples don't put in the effort, but because they are expressing their love in the "wrong" ways. When you learn to understand and speak your spouse's love language, you will be able to effectively express your love and truly feel loved in return.

Introduction



DIFFERENT LOVE LANGUAGES



Like linguistics in communication, people speak different love languages. We have our native love languages that we speak and understand best in, and our secondary language(s) that we are comfortable but less fluent at. It is possible

for couples to love each other, but to feel unloved because they give and receive love differently, i.e. they don't share the same primary emotional love language. After 30 years of marriage counselling, Chapman concluded that there are 5 key emotional love languages, though there are many "dialects" within these 5 languages.

FILLING THE LOVE TANK



All of us have an "emotional love tank". When we receive love in our primary love language, our love tank is filled and we feel loved. When we don't receive love expressed in our primary love language, our love tank gradually depletes and we feel unloved. When our love tank is empty, issues in the relationship arise.



KEY QUOTES

"We must be willing to learn our spouse's primary love language if we are to be effective communicators of love."

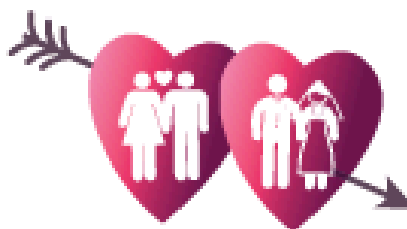
"Once you identify and learn to speak your spouse's primary love language, I believe that you will have discovered the key to a long-lasting, loving marriage."

"At the heart of mankind's existence is the desire to be intimate and to be loved by another. Marriage is designed to meet that need for intimacy and love."

FALLING IN LOVE



When we fall in love, we feel euphoric. We have the illusion that our partners are perfect and that the



romantic feelings in our relationship will last

forever. During this in-love period, we feel altruistic toward each other. We give freely because we believe our lover feels the same about us, & are equally committed to meet our needs.

Long-range studies show that **the in-love phenomenon typically lasts about 2 years** (or longer if it is a secret love affair). When the phase eventually passes, we start to assert ourselves, and we stop doing many of the altruistic things for our partners. Our differences start to surface, and our partners' imperfections start to become irritating or annoying. As the love tanks start to deplete, relationship issues start to surface.

To have a lasting relationship, it is important to recognize that the emotional high of the in-love experience is only temporary in nature. **After the phase has run its course, we need to make a conscious shift to "real love"**. Unlike the in-love stage, real love involves :

- A conscious choice or an act of will to love the other person;
- Effort & discipline to understand and give love to the other person (not merely driven by the euphoria of being "in love"); and
- A focus on growth and development of yourself and your partner (unlike the "in love" phase when we simply see the other party as perfect and hope they will stay that way).

We can choose to learn and speak our spouses' primary love language. When their love tanks are full, they are in a better position to reciprocate your love, and are free to grow to their full potential.



Love Language #1: Words of Affirmation

Words of affirmation are **words that build someone up**. If this is your primary love language, it means the world to you when you receive unsolicited compliments, hear the words "I love you" and the reasons behind that love. Insults can break your heart and leave lasting scars.

KEY QUOTES

"(Real love) is emotional in nature but not obsessional. It is a love that unites reason and emotion. It involves an act of the will and requires discipline, and it recognizes the need for personal growth."

"The in-love experience does not focus on our own growth nor on the growth and development of the other person...We are at the apex of life's happiness, and our only desire is to stay there."

"When we receive affirming words we are far more likely to be motivated to reciprocate and do something our spouse desires."

Verbal compliments

Sincere compliments can help your spouse to feel valued and appreciated: e.g. "You look beautiful today", "You look great in that suit," "I really love your cooking."



Encouraging Words

Your spouse may have areas of insecurity or untapped potential. Your words of encouragement inspire courage, and can be an important catalyst to help your spouse to take action to develop his/ her full potential. These could include:

- **Kind Words**, expressed with a loving tone of voice. This includes making a commitment to forgive each other for our past mistakes, and living each day free from the failures of yesterday.
- **Humble Words**, i.e. making humble requests, not demands, of each other. Recognize that we are equal, adult partners in marriage – when we make requests of our spouse, we affirm them of their abilities and their worth to us; when we make demands, we are belittling them.
- **Other Dialects** e.g.
 - Indirect words of affirmation: Praising your spouse when he/she is not around, or praising your spouse in front of others;
 - Sharing the credit for your accomplishments with your spouse; and
 - Written words of affirmation.



Love Language #2: Quality Time



If this is your primary language, you value **doing things together & receiving full, undivided attention** from your spouse, including sharing quality conversations and activities. Distractions, postponed dates, or not being listened to can be especially hurtful to you.



Quality conversations

Quality conversations involves sharing experiences, thoughts, feelings, desires etc. in a friendly and uninterrupted way.

- **Listen sympathetically and wholeheartedly.** To be a better listener:

KEY QUOTES

"Encouragement requires empathy and seeing the world from your spouse's perspective. We must first learn what is important to our spouse."

"Love doesn't keep a score of wrongs. Love doesn't bring up past failures....Forgiveness is the way of love."

"If we are to develop an intimate relationship, we need to know each other's desires. If we wish to love each other, we need to know what the other person wants."

- *Give your full attention:* Maintain eye contact, and focus on listening (don't do anything else during the conversation)
 - Have a true desire to understand your spouse's thoughts, feelings and desires: *Listen for feelings, observe body language, and seek clarification if necessary, to know what he/she is really thinking and feeling*
 - *Refuse to interrupt*
- **Learn to talk:** Self-revelation is not easy for many of us who grew up in homes where we are discouraged from expressing our thoughts and feelings (especially negative ones). We may have grown to deny our feelings over time.
- *Learn to express your feelings.* Start by writing down your feelings associated with events away from home e.g. "no promotion – disappointed", "long queue – frustrated". Communicate these events and feelings briefly with your spouse, until you start to feel comfortable discussing your emotions about events within the home too.
 - *Establish new patterns of sharing.* Our natural inclination to share/ not share may be influenced by our personality types, but everyone can learn new communication patterns. To learn new patterns of sharing, set a daily sharing time in which each person will talk about 3 things that happened in the day and how you feel about them.



KEY QUOTES

Quality activities

This can include anything in which either or both party has an interest in. The activity itself is less important than the objective of expressing love by being together. This may involve giving up some of your individual activities, but will go a long way to fill your spouse's love tank.



Love Language #3: Receiving Gifts

Gifts are visual symbols of love. If this is your primary language, you deeply treasure a gift or gesture that shows you are being thought of, cared for, and prized above whatever was sacrificed to bring you the gift. You feel hurt by the absence of daily gestures, a missed birthday, anniversary, or a hasty/ thoughtless gift.

"If your spouse's primary love language is receiving gifts, you can become a proficient gift giver. In fact, it is one of the easiest love languages to learn."

Gifts can be purchased, found or made, and the value is often less important than the significance of the gift. If you are not intuitive at giving gifts but your spouse's primary language is receiving gifts, you can start by making a list of all the gifts that your spouse has been excited about – this will give you an idea of what gifts he/she appreciates.



Gifts and Money

If you have a saving and investing mentality, you may feel reluctant to spend money on gifts. Learn to view it as an investment in your spouse and relationship.

The Gift of Self

The gift of self (or the gift of physical presence) becomes especially critical in times of crisis if your spouses' primary love language is receiving gifts. If you are on the receiving end and want your spouse to be present physically, verbalize it rather than expect your spouse to read your mind.



Love Language #4: Acts of Service



If this is your primary love language, you feel loved when your spouse says "let me do that for you", and helps to ease your burdens or share your responsibilities e.g. cooking a meal, washing the car. Broken commitments, unwillingness to help, laziness/sloppiness, or taking your spouse for granted, all send the message that your spouse doesn't matter.

Even if you and your spouse share the same primary love language of Acts of Service, you make speak different "dialects" or value different types of support being rendered. Try asking your spouse to list down the tasks that he/she considers most important, and do them.



We should remember that our perspectives and stereotypes of male and female roles in society/the household may not be shared by our spouse. Hence, it's always better to make requests than demands. No spouse should ever feel compelled to do something for the other due to guilt or fear.



KEY QUOTES

"Physical presence in the time of crisis is the most powerful gift you can give if your spouse's primary love language is receiving gifts."

"Requests give direction to love, but demands stop the flow of love."

"Learning the love language of acts of service will require some of us to reexamine our stereotypes of the roles of husbands and wives."



Love Language #5: Physical Touch



Physical touch can bring a sense of security and connection to any relationship. If this is your primary love language, you crave **shows of care and love through thoughtful touches, hugs, kisses, pats on the back, and/or sexual intercourse**. Neglect or abuse can cause serious damage and hurt to you emotionally.

Dialects in Physical Touch

Like other love languages, there are **different dialects** in physical touch, such as loving touches on the arm/back/shoulders, a back rub, sexual foreplay and intercourse, sitting closely on the couch, holding hands etc.

Get feedback from your spouse to find out which what he/she finds loving and pleasurable. Even if you share the same love language of physical touch, don't assume he/she speaks the same dialect as you.



While **physical abuse** is inappropriate for any society or love language, it has an amplified impact for someone whose primary love language is physical touch. For example, a slap in the face or a spouse's infidelity can cause massive damage emotionally especially to someone whose love is expressed by physical touch.



If your spouse's primary love language is physical touch, holding him/her when he/she is crying or during crises is extremely powerful. On the contrary, the failure to touch could communicate indifference and leave a deep scar.



Discovering your Primary Love Language

To discover your primary love language, ask yourself:

- What makes you feel most loved by your spouse? What do you desire the most from your spouse?
- What does your spouse fail to do or say that hurts you deeply or brings you deepest pain?
- What do you do to express love to your spouse? [You tend to do what you wish he/she would do for you]

KEY QUOTES

"Physical touch can make or break a relationship. It can communicate hate or love."

"If your spouse's primary love language is physical touch, nothing is more important than holding her as she cries."

"Love doesn't erase the past, but it makes the future different. When we choose active expressions of love in the primary love language of our spouse, we create an emotional climate where we can deal with our past conflicts and failures."

The “Tank Check Game”

Use this game to develop your understanding of and stimulate the love expressions in your relationship:



- Write down what you think is your primary love language, then list the other 4 in order of importance. Also write down what you think is the primary love language of your spouse. Sit down and discuss your lists.
- For 3 times a week for 3 weeks, do a “Tank Check”:
 - Ask “On a scale of 0-10, how is your love tank tonight?”
 - Then ask “What could I do to help fill it?” and do what your spouse requests to the best of your ability.
 - The top requests are likely to cluster around your primary love language.

Love is a Choice

We all come down from the emotional high of the in-love experience at some point. Most marriages fail because people have not learnt or chosen to speak the primary love language of the other party. With the love tank empty for some time, people start to fall in love with someone else.



Making a conscious choice and a deliberate effort to speak our spouse’s primary love language may not come naturally for us. But it helps to keep his/her love tank full, and chances are that he/she will reciprocate and speak our language.

Love gives us the security, sense of significance & self-worth, and energy to develop our potential.

Turning things around

If you and your spouse’s love tank have been empty for very long and you want a “miracle” to turn things around, consider this approach:



- Tell your spouse that you have been thinking about your marriage and want to do a better job of meeting his/her needs.
- Ask for suggestions on how you could improve, and be open to the feedback.
- If he/she has no suggestions, guess the primary love language based on the things he/she has been complaining about.
- Focus on speaking that love language for 6 months, and ask

KEY QUOTES

“When your spouse’s emotional love tank is full and he feels secure in your love, the whole world looks bright and your spouse will move out to reach his highest potential in life.”

“True love always liberates.”

for feedback at the end of each month.

- Each time your spouse indicates he or she is seeing improvement, wait for 1 week before making a specific request of what you'd like him/her to do for you.

Love Languages and Children

The 5 love languages apply to children too. When children are little, we should pour all 5 love languages on them. As they grow up, observe their behaviours to learn their primary language.



- **Words of Affirmation:** We usually lavish young children with loving words and praises, but start to make demands and criticisms as they grow older. For a child whose primary love language is words of affirmation, such negative words could leave a long-lasting impact on their sense of self-worth and self-esteem. Instead, commend them for their successes and achievements.
- **Quality Time:** If your children's primary language is quality time, it is especially important for you get involved in their areas of interest and give them undivided attention in their younger years. Otherwise they will probably not allow you to spend time with them in their adolescent years.
- **Receiving Gifts:** If your child's primary love language is receiving gifts, he/she is likely to take care of the gifts, display them prominently, and play with them often. Observe what they value most and express your love through those gifts.
- **Acts of Service:** If your child often expresses appreciation for small acts of service that you do for him/her, and he/ she consistently offers to help you with projects and tasks, this is likely to be the primary language.
- **Physical Touch:** It is natural to hold and hug young children. As they grow up, don't withdraw such acts of affection. Remember that physical punishments can be especially hurtful emotionally to children with this love language.

KEY QUOTES

"Observe your children. Watch how they express love to others. That is a clue to their love language."

Other Useful Details in the Book to Look Out For



Chapman used many real-life examples from his own marriage, and of couples that he had counselled across the years, to illustrate the concepts in his book and how they can be applied to address different marriage/relationship issues and circumstances. These case studies help us to identify similarities and lessons for our own relationships.

In the book, he also offers 2 pages of additional ideas and suggestions for each of the 5 love languages, as well as separate love language profile surveys for husbands and wives (to identify your primary love language). More resources, including free online profiling surveys, are available at the [official website](#).

About the Author



Dr Gary Demonte Chapman (born 1938) is an author and relationship counsellor. He is the director of Marriage and Family Life Consultants, Inc, and also hosts radio programs about marriage and relationships, airing on more than 400 stations. He speaks to thousands of couples through his weekend marriage conferences. He currently live in Winston-Salem, North Carolina, where he serves as senior associate pastor at Calvary Baptist Church.

Dr. Chapman holds BA and MA degrees in anthropology from Wheaton College and Wake Forest University, respectively, MRE and PhD degrees from Southwestern Baptist Theological Seminary, and has completed postgraduate work at the University of North Carolina and Duke University.

With the success of his first book *The Five Love Languages: How to Express Heartfelt Commitment to Your Mate*, he has expanded his *Five Love Languages* series to reach out specifically to singles, men, and parents of teens and young children. He also



READINGGRAPHICS
Ideas Come Alive

KEY QUOTES